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(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Twins and postnatal depression

Caring for 2 or more babies is hard work. For some women, the extra pressure of coping with more than 1 baby can lead to postnatal depression (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/post-natal-depression/).

This does not mean you'll definitely get depressed after having your babies, but mothers of multiple births can be more at risk.

Postnatal depression after having twins

Caring for 2 babies is hard. You constantly have to split your time and attention between them and cannot give them the same type of care you'd give a single baby. Coping with 2 or more babies takes time to get used to.

More than 1 in 10 women get postnatal depression within a year of giving birth. This figure is slightly higher for mothers of multiple babies.

Twins are more likely to be cared for in the neonatal unit (Link: www.nhs.uk/pregnancy/labour-and-birth/special-care-ill-or-premature-babies/). It's thought this could increase the chances of postnatal depression. This is because instead of being able to celebrate your babies' birth, you may be coping with worry, stress and guilt.

Twin pregnancies are also more prone to complications and the birth may be difficult. This means you can begin motherhood feeling low and exhausted.

You may find that the reality of caring for your babies does not match up to your expectations of motherhood.

If your twins are the result of IVF (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/ivf/), for example, it may be hard to discuss these feelings with relatives and friends who assume you're thrilled to have the babies you longed for.

You may also feel:

- envious of mothers with single babies and the mother-child bond they appear to enjoy
- isolated, as it's harder for you to get out than for mothers of single babies
- unsupported, as caring for 2 or more babies is physically and emotionally draining if you do not have enough support

Fathers and postnatal depression

Fathers can also develop postnatal depression. Research suggests about 1 in 10 fathers are affected, but this figure may be higher for fathers of multiples.

Men can find it harder to get support, but it's important to tell a GP if you're feeling anxious or depressed.

You can also call Twinline (the free helpline of the Twins Trust (Link: <https://twinstrust.org/let-us-help/support/twinline.html>)) on 0800 138 0509.

Spotting signs of postnatal depression

It's important to be aware of the signs of postnatal depression because the faster it's diagnosed, the easier it is to treat.

Symptoms of postnatal depression can include:

- crying a lot
- difficulty sleeping
- thinking you're a bad mother
- not being able to cope and blaming yourself
- anxiety (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/generalised-anxiety-disorder/), panic attacks (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/panic-disorder/) and feeling guilty
- being overwhelmed by even the smallest tasks
- feeling tense and irritable
- difficulty concentrating and making decisions

Where to get help

If you have the symptoms of postnatal depression or are feeling low or unable to cope, get help as soon as possible from a GP, your midwife or health visitor.

The Royal College of Psychiatrists website has more information about postnatal depression, including further advice about getting help (Link: <https://www.rcpsych.ac.uk/mental-health/mental-illnesses-and-mental-health-problems/postnatal-depression>)

You can also read more about:

- Postnatal depression: medical advice (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/post-natal-depression/)
- Treatments for postnatal depression (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/post-natal-depression/treatment/)

More in Newborn twins and multiples (Link: www.nhs.uk/baby/newborn-twins-and-multiples/)

Your newborn twins (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/baby/newborn-twins-and-multiples/your-newborn-twins/>)

Twins and sleep (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/baby/newborn-twins-and-multiples/twins-and-sleep/>)

Feeding twins and multiples (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/baby/newborn-twins-and-multiples/feeding-twins-and-multiples/>)

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